Flourish
LEGAL WELL-BEING

# Cheat Sheet: **Seeing Through Negative Thoughts**

We have a tendency to take our thoughts as true. In fact, they're often distorted or simply false.

We can use thought replacement to challenge the validity of our negative thoughts and loosen their hold on us.

## Core Technique

**When a negative thought is troubling you, ask yourself, *"Am I sure that's true?"***

**For extra power, follow up with any of these questions:**

- "What's the evidence that this thought is true?"
- "Am I making any assumptions?"
- "Is there an alternative scenario that's just as plausible?"

## Optional Enhancements

**Identify the type(s) of cognitive distortion present.**

- A CBT app, like Quirk CBT (iPhone) or What's Up? (Android), provides a list of the main cognitive distortions and walks you through the thought-replacement process.

**After challenging the thought, replace it with a more helpful and less distorted one.**

- *E.g.*, "I'm going to mess up this presentation" becomes "I can't know how this presentation will go, but I do know I've prepared extensively, so I've set myself up to do a good job."